

Branches of philosophy



Raphael's famous fresco *The School of Athens* depicts key figures in the history of classical philosophy.

The first philosophers that we know of appeared in the sixth century BCE in ancient Greece. As civilizations became well established and more sophisticated, thinkers began to question traditional explanations for the workings of the universe and society, and sought answers based on rational thought rather than convention or religion. The first question they addressed was 'What is the world made of?' – the branch of philosophy we now call metaphysics. From this, they also began to question how we can be sure of what we know (the branch of epistemology) and the nature of our existence (ontology). Slowly, they developed a systematic way of analysing their arguments, logic and techniques of questioning to elicit fundamental ideas. This opened up the field of moral philosophy, or ethics, which is concerned with concepts such as justice, virtue and happiness, and this in turn led to many philosophers exploring what kind of society we want to live in (giving rise to the branch known as political philosophy).